

## GS Modality & Hedging

### WHAT THIS STRUCTURE MEANS

Modality and hedging is how speakers signal certainty, possibility, obligation, and scope. At ILR 3, hedging is not uncertainty — it is precision. When you hedge, you are telling your listener exactly how confident you are, under what conditions something is true, and where your claim has limits. A hedged argument is a controlled argument.

### WHAT TO TRY

- Use modal verbs to express degrees of certainty: might, may, could, would, should, tend to
- Qualify the scope of your claim: in most cases, under certain conditions, depending on the context
- Signal that your evidence is probabilistic, not absolute: this suggests, evidence indicates, it appears
- Use hedged projections to show consequence: this could lead to, there is a risk that, outcomes may vary
- Acknowledge exceptions without abandoning your position: while this may not apply everywhere...

### SENTENCE STARTERS

- "I think most people would probably agree that... but it is harder to say whether..."
- "This tends to work well in contexts where... but may not apply when..."
- "While it seems reasonable to argue that... the outcomes would likely depend on..."
- "There may be cases where... which suggests that a single approach might not be enough."
- "I am not claiming that... I am saying the evidence seems to point toward..."

### EXAMPLE IN ACTION

Topic: Should governments regulate social media platforms?

*"I think... most governments would **probably** argue they need **some kind of** oversight here, but I'm **not sure** a single regulatory model would work across different political systems. What **tends to happen** — and **this might not apply everywhere** — is that the same policy can function very differently depending on who's enforcing it. So while **it seems reasonable to say** that regulation could reduce harm, **it's harder to say whether** it would actually do that **in practice**. There **may be** cases where it creates different problems. I'm **not claiming** regulation is wrong — I'm saying the outcomes would **likely vary significantly depending on the context**."*

Bold phrases mark active hedging moves. Each one controls scope, certainty, or projection — not just softens the claim.